

ON TECHNIQUE

Creating a Bohemian style

It was the atmosphere, rhythms, and emotional temperature of Czech folk music that seeped into Dvořák's compositions, rather than actual folk songs, which he usually did not quote directly. The dance forms, lively rhythms, and incantatory melodies of Bohemian folk music became part of his language. His Slavonic Dances and "Dumky" Trio (1891) are prime examples: the latter's movements are all based on the alternation of slow and fast sections found in the dumky, a traditional folk dance.



CZECH FOLK DANCES, ENGRAVING, 19TH
CENTURY

New and old worlds

Soon after he arrived, Thurber gave him a copy of Longfellow's epic poem *The Song of Hiawatha*, suggesting he might create from it a great US opera. Dvořák investigated suitable sources of US musical sounds. It was not long before he declared he had found exactly what was required—namely, African-American